Te Reo Māori

Executive Summary

Te reo Māori is the heartbeat of this whenua and continues to bespeak this land we all call home. It carries whakapapa, memory, tikanga, and the authority of our tīpuna. When te reo is weakened, so too is our collective identity and authority over the land.

For generations, te reo Māori was deliberately suppressed; punished in schools, excluded from public life, and framed as optional or expendable. Despite this, whānau, hapū, and iwi never let it die.

Te Pāti Māori will ensure te reo Māori is protected, normalised, and passed confidently to future generations, not as a cultural courtesy, but as a foundational language of Aotearoa.

Context

Although te reo Māori is recognised as an official language, its daily use remains fragile. Access to quality reo education is uneven. Public services often treat bilingualism as piecemeal and optional. Too much responsibility is still placed on whānau to carry revitalisation alone.

Language loss is structural and reflects political choices.

Revitalisation also requires political will. Te reo Māori must be upheld as a living language, used naturally in homes, schools, workplaces, and public institutions. Policy settings must reflect this choice to revitalise the language.

Our Position

Te reo Māori is a tāonga guaranteed protection under Te Tiriti o Waitangi. It belongs to this land and must be visible, audible, respected and integrated across all domains of public life.

Revitalisation is not achieved through symbolism alone. It requires structural commitment, sustained investment, and accountability across all institutions of government.

Normalising Te Reo Māori

Te reo Māori must be part of modern life in Aotearoa, and not something people have to ask for.

Te Pāti Māori will...

- Make te reo Māori compulsory within the education system, with age-appropriate progression.
- End “opt-in” and discretionary approaches to reo provision.
- Ensure te reo Māori is treated as a normal language of communication in Aotearoa.

1. Te Reo in Public Institutions

The Crown must model the behaviour it expects from society.

- Require public institutions and agencies to operate bilingually.
- Embed te reo Māori across legislation, policy, and service delivery.
- Ensure public servants are resourced and supported to learn and use te reo Māori confidently.

2. Whānau- and Marae-led Revitalisation

Language lives where people live and thrives within environments that enable it to do so.

- Fund whānau-led, marae-based, hapū and iwi reo initiatives.
- Support iwi language strategies and long-term revitalisation planning.
- Protect regional dialects and tikanga-specific reo traditions.

3. Media, Broadcasting, and Digital Reo

Modern language survival requires modern platforms.

- Strengthen Māori media and broadcasting in te reo Māori.
- Support digital platforms, content creation, and innovation that grows te reo usage.

4. Accountability and Protection

Language gains must not be held hostage by political change.

- Establish protections to prevent rollback of te reo Māori commitments.
- Ensure long-term, stable investment in reo revitalisation, including for Te Reo Māori broadcasting.
- Hold the Crown accountable for upholding its Tiriti obligations to te reo Māori.

Our Commitment

Te reo Māori will not survive on goodwill alone, it will survive through active protection, normalisation, and transmission.